

The Language of the Freedmen in Petronius' Cena Trimalchionis by Bret Boyce
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Bret Boyce: *The Language of the Freedmen in Petronius' Cena Trimalchionis.* Leiden/New York/København/Köln: Brill 1991. VI, 113 S. (Mnemosyne, Suppl. 117.) 70 hfl.

Like many dissertations rushed into print, this «revised form» of a 1989 Brown University dissertation proves difficult to evaluate: as a dissertation, it was an acceptable treatment of a difficult topic, testifying to the author's potential for productive work; as a scholarly contribution to the subject, it is distinctly less successful.

In terms of presentation, the opportunity that formal publication provided for careful editing, proofreading, and indexing has been squandered. The legions of typographical and other errors, while mostly self-correcting, are frequently grating and constantly distracting.[1] The 'Index' (109–113) is actually an Index Nominum; but for an author with such a limited corpus, and given B.'s many discussions of individual words, an Index Verborum (and for syntactic problems an Index Locorum) would have enhanced the value of the book. As it is, the 'Index' (Nominum) is seriously defective: entries and page references record only persons appearing in the body of the text, but not in footnotes.

More substantive problems can be addressed after summarizing the book's contents. Chapter One, 'Introduction' (1–35), surveys the representation of lower-class and foreign diction in Greek and Roman literature, and sketches the history of scholarship on the 'vulgar' Latin in Petronius; Chapter Two, 'Popular Features in the Language of the Freedmen' (36–75), examines «the nature and extent of Petronius' imitation of plebeian speech» via subsections sketching details of 'Phonology' , 'Morphology', 'Lexicon', and 'Syntax'; and Chapter Three, 'Language and Characterization of the Freedmen' (76–102), discusses the speech of individual freedmen, with short sections on Dama, Seleucus, and Phileros, and more extended treatments of Ganymedes, Echion, Niceros, Habinnas, Hermeros, and Trimalchio.

In Chapter One, B.'s rambling discussions (3–9) of foreign speech in Greek drama and mime contain several interesting observations, but have little direct bearing on his subject, and seem grafted on from some other (and more broadly-conceived) dissertation.[2] More germane is B.'s judicious (if conventional) evaluation of the colloquial element in Plautus (10–12),[3] and his sensible (if unoriginal)

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[1] E. g.: *apellant* (p. 36), *pecavisse* (91), «parasyllabic» (93), and the pervasive «occurence» (conversely «dissappearance», 6); garbled names (P. Burman as «Burmann», L. Threatte as «Threattie», W. Trask [104, Auerbach 1953] as «Traske», G. Bonfante as «Bonafante» on p. 104, but correctly elsewhere, even «Platon» for 'Petron' [104, Delz 1977], «Trimalcion» for 'Trimalchion' [108, Väänänen 1969]); solecisms («the use of abbreviating symbols ... have given rise», 46; the «fourth or the fifth» [scil. conjugation classes], 54); dittographic lapses (both languages: «created by by», 27; *devorarare,* 59); etc.

[2] B.'s linguistic analyses of these passages are generally inconclusive, as he readily admits, given the difficulty of disengaging 'vulgarisms' from 'foreignisms'; and B. seems to underestimate the complexity of some of the material. Thus Herodas «eschews linguistic realism even when treating realistic themes and chooses instead to use an artificial literary dialect», «[l]ike other Hellenistic writers, such as Theocritus in *Idylls* 2, 14, and 15» (9); but the facile comparison with Theocritus ignores C. J. Ruijgh's attempt to demonstrate a relatively complex and highly «realistic» dialectal mixture in poem 15 (Mnemosyne 37, 1984, 78 ff).

[3] «... while the strong colloquial element in Plautus is undeniable, we should be careful not automatically to label anything we encounter in his comedies as 'spoken' or 'popular' Latin» (12), a conclusion with which scarcely anyone would disagree.

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observations (13f) concerning the linguistic (as opposed to purely thematic) affinities between Petronius and the language of mime and Atellan farce.

From the point of view of genre, B.'s most evocative comparison concerns the Greek romance (9f): here B. finds that in the canonic authors, «the style ... is essentially uniform, and makes little attempt at linguistic differentiation of the speech of the various characters according to social class». This is in marked contrast to the Iolaus papyrus fragment (P. Oxy. 3010): following the lead of P. Parsons' preliminary comparisons with Petronius (BICS 18, 1971, 53ff), B. interprets some of the alleged 'vulgarisms' of this text to show that «the author has deliberately employed non-standard forms to characterize linguistically the disreputable speaker». All such forms, however, occur in the Sotadeans addressed by the *gallus* to Iolaus; in view of Petronius' use of Sotadeans in similar contexts (23.3, 132.8),[4] a point not noted by B., the problem is evidently more complex, and might have benefited from a more sustained discussion.[5]

The remainder of Chapter One surveys major scholarly treatments of the 'vulgar' Latin in Petronius, from the rediscovery of H in the mid-seventeenth century through J. Hosner's 1984 Bochum dissertation, Studien zur lateinisch-romanischen Sprachentwicklung am Beispiel der gesprochenen Partien in der 'Cena Trimalchionis'. Here B.'s principal service is his highlighting of older (esp. 17th- and early 19th-c.) investigations, which may help to dispel the still common misconception that «[t]he discussion of the *sermo urbanus* and the *sermo vulgaris* or *sermo plebeius* begins with Buechler [sic; i.e. Buecheler – BV] in his edition of 1867 [sic; i.e. 1862 – BV]» (thus N. Slater, op. cit. 147 n. 9). Among B.'s critiques of numerous later works, the bulk of his attention (25–30) is devoted to the important study of H. L. W. Nelson.[6] Since, as B. notes, this work «remains today the most comprehensive investigation of the subject», B. not unnaturally sets Nelson up as his main foil, finding in Nelson's work «a pervasive tendency ... to underrate the extent to which the language of the freedmen in Petronius reflects actual popular usage» (34). The «immediate task» of B.'s study, then, is «to reexamine in more specific terms the nature and extent of Petronius' imitation of plebeian speech», via the sketches of linguistic features that make up Chapter Two.

From Chapter Two, however, B.'s simplistic strategy soon emerges: selected linguistic features are first provided with superficial descriptions; they are then confronted with parallel 'popular' material, derived mainly from two sources: V. Väänänen's handbook of 'vulgar Latin',[7] and especially his study of Pompeiian Latin;[8] and A. Stefenelli's study of Petronian linguistic features with Romance comparanda.[9] Even when B.'s arguments are not vitiated by his over-reliance on

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[4] See now E. Courtney, The Poems of Petronius, Atlanta 1991, 19f, 33f.

[5] B.'s simplistic treatment of prosimetric genres is innocent of the work in this area conducted since the early 1970's by D. Bartoňková (on the Iolaus fragment: esp. SPFB 30, 1985, 125ff); on Sotadeans more generally, see now N. Slater, Reading Petronius, Baltimore/London 1990, 184f.

[6] Petronius en zijn 'vulgair' latijn. Een stilistisch-grammatische studie over de zoogenaamde 'vulgaire dictie' in de Cena Trimalchionis. Deel I. Inleiding en formeelgrammatische problemen, Alphen aan den Rijn 1947 (diss. Utrecht).

[7] B. without explanation cites from the second edition (Introduction au latin vulgaire,[2] Paris 1967), not the third edition of 1981 ('revue et augmentée').

[8] Le latin vulgaire des inscriptions pompéiennes,[3] Berlin 1966.

[9] Die Volkssprache im Werk des Petron im Hinblick auf die romanischen Sprachen, Wien 1962.

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Väänänen and Stefenelli,[10] his analyses generally provide no advance over Nelson's linguistically more nuanced ones.

Some of the deficiencies of B.'s phonological analysis can be illustrated by his discussion of the 'sonus medius' ('ĭ > ŭ', 37f, cf. *optimus/optumus* etc.). B. comments that the survival of allegedly 'popular' *u* for *i* is well-attested in Pompeiian inscriptions, «generally before labial consonants», but he then loses sight of this phonetic conditioning in his analysis of forms like 57.7 *peduculum,* 63.8 *manuciolus,* 65.11 *ossucula* (beside 58.4 *dupondii,* 69.3 *ipsumam* [Trimalchio] etc.). In attempting to reject Nelson's conception of the problem (op. cit. 31f), B. fails to appreciate the linguistic sophistication of Nelson's approach, which properly distinguishes the pre-labial cases (spelled with predictable inconsistency in H, as in other manuscripts: thus beside 69.3 *ipsumam* [Trimalchio] also 63.3 *ipsimi* [id.], etc.), from others like *ossucula* (cf. the *u*-stem attested in inscriptional OSSVA) or *manuciolus* (with *u*-stem basis), in which derivational morphology (and not, as B. prefers, a phonetically-based 'popular vocalization') must play a role, if not the dominant role. Many other infelicities in B.'s phonological discussion could be cited,[11] and B.'s most interesting observations are generally not original.[12]

B.'s treatment of morphology (46ff) is equally unsatisfactory. B. discusses 'Change of Voice' (51f) without knowledge of P. Flobert's fundamental treatment,[13] which reevaluates a number of 'active-for-deponent' and 'deponent-for-active' forms: see e. g. Flobert 195, 210ff for alleged Petronian 'hypercorrect' or 'hyperurban' passives (of the type 47.4 *pudeatur,* 57.3 *rideatur,* etc.).[14] Similarly, the simplistic treatment of 'Change of Conjugation' (52f) begs many questions.

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[10] B., for example, blindly follows Väänänen in assuming Oscan substratum influence on Pompeiian phonology (e. g. p. 74), but see J. Eska, The Language of the Latin Inscriptions of Pompeii and the Question of an Oscan Substratum, Glotta 65, 1987, 146ff.

[11] E. g.: the discussion of 'ĭ > ę' (37) confusingly adduces 59.5 *Efigeniam* (E- for Ī-; e. g. Juv. 12.119 line-initial) and 64.2,4 *deverbia (dī-);* the archaic/dialectal status of *e* for *i* in forms of the type FILEA (e. g. CIL I² 60; Praeneste, 3rd c. B. C.), not noted by B., has not been assessed in his discussion of allegedly 'hypercorrect' forms of a similar type (41); on *fericulum* (43) see my remarks in Glotta 67, 1989, 127ff, and for epenthetic *r* (45f, type 66.5 *frustrum* vs. 66.7 *frusta* [both Habinnas], the latter miscited [twice] by B. as *frustum*), ibid. 132 n. 14; the description of syncope (42) operates with a phonetically improper term «weak vowels» (unless B. means to claim neutralization of vowel length for Pompeiian Latin); the statement (44) of the fricativization process [w] > [β] sloppily omits the restriction to syllable-initial position (for a further phonetic restriction see now L. Stephens, TAPA 118, 1988, 421ff, with rich bibliography); the analysis of the *-m-* of 42.6 *lamellulas* (Hermeros) via a popular assimilation of **lamnellulas* (44) is specious (rather *lamell-* < **lamen-l-;* M. Leumann, Lateinische Laut- und Formenlehre, Munich 1977, 306), and the confusing typographical error *lamna(m)* on the same page (an alternative to the *lamna(m)* printed by editors for 57.4 *lāna,* 58.8 *lāna* [sic H]) presumably stands for *lamma(m)* or *lanna(m).*

[12] For the pattern 77.4 *susum* vs. *sursum/deorsum* (58.5, 63.9), «perhaps to preserve the homoioteleuton» (B. 44f, after Nelson, op. cit. 51), cf. similar patterns for these items in the Sententia Minuciorum (CIL I² 584), as I discuss elsewhere (Studies in Archaic Latin Inscriptions, Innsbruck 1993, 262ff).

[13] Les verbes déponents latins des origines à Charlemagne, Paris 1975.

[14] Here again, B.'s over-dependence on Väänänen's Pompeiian material is apparent: while B. duly cites Pompeiian data for non-classical actives, he asserts that «[t]he opposite phenomenon, the use of deponent in place of active, runs counter to the historical development and is not attested in the Pompeian [sic] inscriptions», ignoring the Capuan form FLORERI (CIL I² 1603, cf. Flobert 197f). For further discussion of FLORERI (together with the possibly similar Capuan NOCEREI, CIL I² 3121) in connection with the Petronian forms, see my study referred to above (n. 12), 147ff.

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Thus B. seems to regard the *defraudit* of H (69.2, Trimalchio) as a certain example of «defection from the first declension [sic] to the third», while Trimalchio's *non olunt* (50.7, H *nolunt*)[15] «possibly» furnishes a similar second- to third-conjugation example. In fact, most editors (e. g. Müller, Smith) regard *olunt* as tolerably certain, on the strength of similar OLat. instances (Plt. *Poen.* 268 *olant* etc.), while preferring to print the emendation *defraudat*, there being no independent evidence for a **fraudĕre*.[16] As for 'Syncopated Conjugation' (53f), B. correctly minimizes the import of this feature for evaluating the freedmen's speech (although citation of G. Bendz' important study[17] would have been helpful).[18] But B. then claims that Habinnas' *erudibam* (Jahn's virtually certain emendation for the *audibant* of H at 68.6) is «[f]ar more distinctively vulgar», since «[t]he ending *-ibam* eventually completely supplanted *-iebam* in the spoken language», entirely ignoring – as Nelson did not, in his discussion of *erudibam* (op. cit. 93) – the frequency of *-ibam* in literary Latin, beginning with Ennius (*Ann.* 42 Sk *stabilibant*). Indeed, for the single instance in which B. correctly disputes Nelson's position, with respect to the 'Change of Gender' in forms of the type *caelus* (39.5,6 [Trimalchio]), B.'s slightly overwrought polemics (29f, 46f) attack a straw man: B.'s 'popular language' interpretation of such forms (cf. the loss of the neuter in Romance) has been widely accepted for some time (see e. g. Smith's commentary ad 39.4 *fer[i]culus*).

The treatment of 'Lexicon' (54ff) is subdivided into sections on 'word-formation' and 'lexical choice'; both are disappointing. As for word-formation, B. plausibly suggests that «[a] complete reexamination of the problem of word formation in Petronius in a way that is sensitive to dramatic context and based on a modern edition ... is really in order», but foregoes this task, as «beyond the scope of the present work». This is a pity. Instead, B. is content to demonstrate that certain features identified with 'popular language' (suffixes *-arius/-arium*, compounding, use of diminutives, etc.) «occur more frequently in the speech of the freedmen than in urbane diction».[19] Far more illuminating than this scattershot sketch (which omits many points of interest, such as the status of Greek affixes and Greek-Latin hybrid formations, or frequentative verbs) would have been a careful sifting of the primary data and the secondary literature surrounding even a few of these items.

Thus for diminutives, B. merely observes that «[t]he freedmen also employ diminutives with great frequency», without reference to such works as G. Tarditi's pioneering study,[20] which, apart from its semantic and stylistic differentiation among various types of diminutives, includes interesting comparative remarks on the usage of diminutives by both Encolpius and the freedmen. As for 'lexical choice' (58–60): B. does little more than provide a tabular summary of the distribution of sets of 'synonyms' like *animal/bestia*, *pulcher/formosus/bellus* etc. in urbane vs. freedmen's speech, with predictable (and statistically meager) results, and without improving on Nelson's rich discussion of many individual cases (op. cit. 112–133), or even citing more recent treatments.[21] Throughout B.'s consideration of

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[15] In defense of *non olunt* see most recently J. Linderski, HarvSt 94, 1992, 349 n. 1.

[16] The semi-deponent passive *frausus sit* (Plt. *As.* 286 and glosses) is to be interpreted differently; Flobert, op. cit. 501.

[17] 'Kontrahierte und nicht kontrahierte Formen des Perfektstammes', pp. 51–3 of his 'Sprachliche Bemerkungen zu Petron', Eranos 39, 1941, 27ff.

[18] For more on syncopated forms in Petronius, see my remarks in AJPh 109, 1988, 543ff, and the slight modification suggested by Slater, op. cit. 151 n. 17.

[19] Even this limited goal is undermined by B.'s failure to address the question of statistical significance.

[20] I diminutivi nel Satyricon di Petronio, Genoa 1951.

[21] P. Soverini's study of several such sets (RAIB 64, 1975/6, 173ff) is listed in the bibliography, but nowhere cited in the section on 'Lexicon'.

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lexicon, finally, the lack of any reference to the work of J. N. Adams[22] constitutes a most surprising omission, in view of Adams' interesting findings concerning freedmen's speech in general, Trimalchio's speech in particular, and a number of individual vocables and their formation.[23]

By B.'s own admission, his treatment of 'Syntax' (61ff) is «largely limited to a review of the results of» Nelson (op. cit., 134–187) and H. Petersmann;[24] thus B.'s errors and omissions need not detain us overmuch.[25] It is especially disappointing, however, that B.'s 'syntax' is entirely traditional (cases, tenses, moods, prepositions, etc.), and that the last two decades of advances in pragmatics and discourse analysis did not pique B. to examine other areas that might well have benefited from further study, such as word order or intersentential coordination.[26]

In Chapter Three, B. offers, with annoyingly Eumolpan prolixity, comparative studies of language and character for the individual freedmen. In the end, however, B. fails to grapple with the basic circularity introduced by the variables of 'sample size' and content: thus, at the two extremes, the eight-sentence speech of Dama (with conventional pronouncements on eating, the weather, bathing, and drinking) shows a «simplicity and directness» which «reflect his monochromatic personality» (77), whereas the language of Trimalchio, attested in extenso, is «an exotic hybrid embracing the most refined turns of phrase as well as the most glaring vulgarisms», and thus «a faithful reflection of his personality, an improbable compound of fancy, social pretension, and earthy reality» (102). Not surprisingly, the description of the speech-style of Hermeros (90ff), who speaks more than any other freedman except Trimalchio, reaches a level of complexity not unlike that found for Trimalchio. Since the chapter (and therefore the book) lacks a conclusion, we do not know, for example, whether the strong hypercorrecting tendencies

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[22] The Latin Sexual Vocabulary, Baltimore 1982.

[23] See e. g. Adams, op. cit. 34 (proverbial expressions), 66 («The freedmen in Petronius do not as a rule use obscenities»), 147 (Trimalchio's use of *debattuere,* see also 215), 111f (*cula* and *apoculo,* including hybrid formations, 112 n. 1), 204 (euphemistic *facio*), etc.

[24] Petrons urbane Prosa: Untersuchungen zu Sprache und Text (Syntax), Vienna 1977.

[25] E. g.: the discussion of 'personal pronouns' (67f) considers only third-person pronouns, without reference to the much-discussed questions surrounding first- and second-person subject pronouns (see e. g. Petersmann, op. cit. 45ff; H. Pinkster, in Études de linguistique générale et de linguistique latine offertes en hommage à Guy Serbat, Paris 1987, 369ff); the discussion of 46.2 *persuadeam* as a late/vulgar potential subjunctive that has «encroached upon the terrain of the future» (69f) ignores the alternative (and to my mind superior) analysis of S. Jannaccone, GIF 16, 1963, 199ff (1sg. future *-ebo/-eam* analogical after the frequent OLat. type *scibo/sciam* etc., cf. Apul. *Met.* prol. *permulceam* parallel with *conseram*); etc.

[26] About J. Feix's compendious 'Wortstellung und Satzbau in Petrons Roman' (diss. Breslau 1934), B. says only, in his introduction (25), that it «contains certain remarks of relevance for the language of the freedmen», but does not return to the matter. More recently, note D. G. J. Panhuis, The Communicative Perspective in the Sentence: A Study of Latin Word Order, Amsterdam/Philadelphia 1982, esp. Ch. IV ('Colloquial Latin: Patterns, Problems, Prospects', based on Plautine material), and esp. G. Hinojo, Del orden de palabras en el Satiricón, in: Symbolae Ludovico Mitxelena septuagenario oblatae, I, ed. J. L. Melena, Vitoria 1985, 245ff, cf. also id., SZ 7, 1986, 79ff (on word order in the *Peregrinatio Aetheriae,* with comparison to Petronius); M. von Albrecht, Masters of Roman Prose from Cato to Apuleius: Interpretative Studies, Leeds 1989 (available to B. in the original German edition of 1979), esp. 130ff on 'elliptical expression' and 'sentence connection' in Petronius.

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B. claims to be significant for Trimalchio differ from the same feature seen in Echion's speech in a qualitative or simply a quantitative way. It remains possible that some progress can be made by analyzing certain features, such as Hermeros' often-noted penchant for Grecisms, with more philological and statistical rigor than B. musters.[27] In the meantime, however, it seems most judicious to accept Slater's recent formulation (op. cit. 150f): «differences among the individual freedmen ... are expressed more often through the content and occasion than the form of their language», and more generally: «The effect is of a language system independent of the individual speaker .... Consequently it is difficult to distinguish between individual freedmen on the basis of language: their much-praised realism consists more in their deviations from the *sermo urbanus* than in distinctions among themselves».

Princeton *Brent Vine*

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Apuleius, Metamorphoses. Edited and translated by **J. Arthur Hanson.** In two volumes. I: Books I–VI; II: Books VII–XI. Cambridge, Mass./London: Harvard UP 1989. xviii, 371; v, 377 S. (The Loeb classical library. 44. 45.) je 18,50 $.[1]

Apuleius is one of the few ancient authors of whom prose works in widely differing genres have survived. Much more work of even more generic divergence has been lost, witness the still inadequately published fragments and testimonies. The amount of scholarly attention given to his rhetorical and philosophical prose, however, is sadly small in comparison with the lavish learned output dealing with the *Metamorphoses* – a work Apuleius himself (one fancies) would be most surprised to see described as his chief legacy.

The new Loeb edition of Apuleius' Metamorphoses is much to be welcomed. Its author, J. Arthur Hanson, regrettably died a number of years before his important work could be published and thus could not benefit from the spate of scholarship on the *Metamorphoses* produced during the last half dozen years. The two volumes replace one whose many faults may now be hidden away under the *volatilis dei pinnae roscidae* and present, after a brief introduction, both a readable text and a lucid, sometimes beautiful, translation. Footnotes to the translation explain obscure references and a useful index provides a great deal more than the usual list of names by including *inter alia multa* a selection of topoi and motifs.

Scholarly praise rarely being unreserved however, the present reviewer has – apart from a brief note on the introduction – rather numerous remarks to make on the text and the critical notes appended to it as well as the translation.

The introduction deals succinctly with the person Apuleius and his work, in so far as it survives.

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[27] Thus, in his enumeration of such items (92f), B. cites 37.6 *lupatria* according to its standard interpretation as a hybrid, without noting G. Neumann's important remarks on hybrid formations and his alternative analysis of *lupatria*, WüJbb N. F. 6a, 1980, 173ff.

[1] R. Th. van der Paardt and M. Zimmerman-de Graaf kindly read the first draft of this review. I owe them thanks for some valuable suggestions.

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